

Finish Strong: Chasing the Olympic Dream

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Preface

Every journey begins with a single step, but what propels us forward is the unwavering determination to chase our dreams. Finish Strong chronicles my path from island shores to the competitive arenas of Canada, culminating in my pursuit of the Olympic stage. This book is a testament to resilience, passion, and the unbreakable spirit that drives us to overcome obstacles and achieve greatness. Through personal anecdotes, universal lessons, and practical advice, I hope to inspire others to pursue their dreams with relentless determination and unwavering faith.

Introduction

Growing up in the Caribbean, sports were not merely activities but a way of life. From soccer games to cricket matches to track and field competitions, our community thrived on athletic spirit year-round. This environment fostered my passion for sports and laid the foundation for my Olympic dreams. Moving to Canada at ten years old introduced new challenges and opportunities, shaping my journey in profound ways. You'll read my journey through the highs and lows, triumphs and tribulations that defined my path to the Olympics, highlighting the essential role of discipline and community support.

Chapter One: Childhood Training

Embracing the Athletic Culture

Training for sports as a child was natural since sports were everywhere across the community all year long. Every Sunday after church, we would gather at the local field to watch soccer matches with community teams. The air buzzed with excitement and the sounds of laughter and cheers. Everyone—men, women, and children—would be there, cheering on their favorite teams, eating, and enjoying each other's company. The vibrant atmosphere was a testament to our shared love for sports and the unbreakable spirit that binds us together as a community.

In my opinion, dancing should also have been considered a sport because of the intense dance-offs we had every weekend. Once Friday came around, we would challenge each other to see who was the best dancer. It may have seemed like casual fun to others, but to me and many of my friends, it was serious business. We needed perfect rhythm, complexity, and precision to outdo the other kids and win the ultimate reward—bragging rights.

When we weren't competing against each other, the community would always connect through music. Like any Jamaican community, when they heard one of our favorite songs playing on the jukebox, everyone would stop what they were doing and start singing and dancing—or they would gather to laugh at how bad someone else's dance moves were. When I was a child in Jamaica, there was no such thing as playing a song just once. We would always say, "Run it again!" when the song finished, and by the time our "dance party" was over, our clothes would be soaked in sweat. Hence, cross-training and preparation for competition the following week became a routine filled with joy and camaraderie.

Early Competitions and Determination

My first training began at three years old, playing different sports in the yard. This included cricket, soccer, football, and of course running races to always win. I would only compete against the boys because most girls were busy reading and doing their hair. That was not for me; I needed something more active than that. Hence, I only played with boys because they were focused on sports—and also because I wanted to beat them.

At five years old, I participated in my first track meet at the school field near Beerfoot. It was fun, and I enjoyed it immensely. All the teachers, students, and parents who weren't working attended and cheered loudly for everyone. Most of them seemed like they wanted to run the race with their children or wished they could enter and run it themselves. It was exciting to see the joy on their faces watching us so proudly.

Despite the lack of soccer or cricket teams for girls in public schools, I continued to play privately in the yard with neighbors' sons. Training for running races was done at lunchtime at school or racing to run errands to the store for my family, ensuring I stayed active and prepared. Additionally, part of my other

training was strength and endurance training—walking to school five days a week which meant climbing a steep hill five times a day for eight months. Needless to say, I slept very well at night.

From ages six to eight, I trained hard every year, winning or placing in the top three at school competitions. Competitions were always at the school, but since the school year had started only students and teachers were cheering. School competitions were nerve-wracking as no one wanted to be teased if they lost, especially when they were walking home after school.

A Defining Moment

At ten years old, during my first year in Junior High, I participated in my first major competition—the provincial championship. I intensified my training by focusing on strength, cardio, and speed, training longer and faster each day. I won the preliminary races and prepared for the finals at the community stadium. I had never been so nervous in my life as I would not stop shaking. These were kids from all over the parish/province gathered at the community stadium.

There was one particular girl who seemed to be just as prepared as me, so I knew she would be my main competition for the title. We were all called to the starting line, and it was hard for me to breathe due to my asthma. The gun went off, bang, and I took off right next to the other girl. As we neared the finish line, I lost my composure, and she crossed first, winning the race. I told myself I would never lose another race again! It was a lesson in humility, perseverance, and the relentless pursuit of excellence.

Chapter Two: New Beginnings in Canada

Adapting to a New Country

Moving to Canada at ten years old marked the beginning of new beginnings. For three years, I found myself missing my island's landscapes—beaches, mountains, rivers, and waterfalls. Most importantly, I missed my best friend and grandmother, whom I used to spend countless hours talking, laughing, and sharing moments with.

The transition to a new country brought its own set of challenges. Adapting to harsh Canadian winters was no easy feat, making outdoor training nearly impossible initially. However, these challenges taught me the importance of perseverance and adaptability. Each day in the snow became an opportunity for resilience.

Expanding Horizons: Diverse Training in Canada

My early years in Canada were a mix of diverse sports and activities. Over the first three years, I trained in floor hockey, basketball, volleyball, gymnastics, soccer, baseball, and running long distance and short sprints. My initial struggles to excel quickly turned into a profound joy as I realized this new country offered boundless opportunities.

During these early days, I would use walking or running through the deep snow to get to school as my toughest training sessions. On recesses, I would utilize every available amenity—doing pull-ups on the monkey bars for abdominal work, or sliding to improve speed. These activities not only enhanced my physical strength and endurance but also instilled in me the value of versatility — all while being fun.

Being proficient in multiple disciplines made me a well-rounded athlete. This skill set prepared me for various competitive environments and opened many doors in sports, academics, and hobbies such as playing piano or recreational racquetball. The outstanding teachers and staff at my schools became a family to me, providing unwavering support on my journey.

Supportive Community and Mentorship

At this pivotal stage of my life, I felt a sense of purpose, but wasn't sure what it was. During Junior High, track and field quickly became my forte. I excelled in all events, setting records and winning championships. The ball sports like basketball and soccer were integral to my training regimen for short sprints, while gymnastics honed inner strength and flexibility.

My biggest competition came at the provincial level, where I faced some of the best athletes from around the province and even nationally. Despite the fierce rivalry, I consistently placed in the top three, driven by a mix of passion and determination.

Discovering Hockey: A New Passion

Watching sports on TV was part of my routine, but understanding the complexities of Canadian and American Football and Hockey took years to grasp. It wasn't until high school that I saw a hockey puck for the first time in the stands during a figure skating competition. As I picked up the puck and laughed, it dawned on me what they shoot and score. The excitement was palpable as fans celebrated goals with cheers, laughter, and sometimes even half-drunk celebrations.

It wasn't long before I witnessed world-class athletes competing at World Outdoor and Indoor Championships, Commonwealth Games, and eventually, my ultimate goal—the Olympics. These events inspired me to set new objectives for myself, first by becoming part of the Provincial Teams and then the Canadian Teams.

My favorite sport remained volleyball. I dedicated countless hours to practice, ensuring I was one of the best players in the city. When teammates were at summer camps, I couldn't afford to join them but continued to train diligently against a wall. These practices helped me maintain my edge as the top player in my sport, driven by passion and determination.

Chapter Three: Training for the Olympics

Intensified High School Training

During my high school years, training became a rigorous daily routine. My schedule increased to three times a day, six days a week. The hardest part was having to jog 30 minutes to get to school on time for three years. This meant I was already exhausted by the time classes started. After school, I had to balance practice with games and other commitments, often coming home late. Despite these long days, I managed to complete my chores and homework before bed, sometimes falling asleep out of sheer exhaustion.

The increased training schedule required meticulous time management and unwavering dedication. Balancing academics and athletics taught me the importance of discipline and prioritization, skills that would prove invaluable in all aspects of my life.

Leadership on the Track

During the spring, I took on a new role as a coach for my high school track team while still training for city championships. Staying focused was crucial. Over three consecutive years, I became the city champion in every event, along with provincial championships and relay team victories. Leading the track team honed my leadership abilities and fostered a sense of responsibility and community.

Guiding younger athletes inspired me to give back and support others in their athletic journeys, further cementing my commitment to excellence. The experience of mentoring these young talents was incredibly rewarding.

Volleyball Achievements and Recognition

My high school volleyball team consistently excelled, often finishing as city finalists or champions. These accomplishments were the result of hard work and dedication, paving the way for my Olympic aspirations and earning me a full university scholarship. On graduation day, I wore a dress for the first time, surprising everyone who had seen me in tracksuits for three years.

After the ceremony, I celebrated by going to the movie theatre for the first time. The experience was so enjoyable that I tried popcorn with extra butter—a small but significant treat.

Dedication Post-Graduation: The Road Intensifies

After high school, I dedicated myself entirely to training for the Olympics. My training program doubled in intensity, consisting of morning runs, strength training during lunch, and evening track workouts lasting three hours each day. Saturdays were filled with short runs and strength exercises.

Traveling every weekend since junior high for competitions was both exhilarating and challenging. Despite the long bus rides, I managed to maintain a strict schedule, often traveling to different cities to compete. These experiences taught me resilience and determination.

National Recognition, Breaking Records, and Overtraining

During my high school years, I made the Canadian Legions Team, broke records, and won medals. But most importantly, I formed lasting friendships along the way. After high school, I joined the Western Canada Teams and the Canada Summer Games Team, where I consistently won all my events. After those were completed, my attention now focused on the Olympic Trials.

Moving to another city for Olympic training was daunting but necessary to me, so I could achieve my Olympic qualification. I was training with a team led by a national coach — whose assigned workouts for me were every day of the week. The physical demands were immense; sometimes I felt like I was about to pass out during sessions. Despite the intense schedule, I trained relentlessly because I truly wanted to make it to the Olympics, and this coach had a history of helping athletes get there. However, I could never have expected what came next.

The rigorous training eventually took its toll, and I ended up breaking a bone in my foot. Medical support was limited because of the kind of injury it was, so all they could do was put a cast on. The injury was a significant setback, challenging not only my physical capabilities but also my mental resilience. Here I was, running the fastest time in the country, now facing the decision of whether I should attend the Olympic Trials with a broken foot. My situation was, unfortunately, not uncommon, as there have been numerous cases both during and after my career of coaches overtraining athletes and causing injury. As I rested and did some topical treatments on the foot, I took some time to think, and ultimately decided to push through and try to accomplish my goal.

Chapter Four: Trials and Triumphs

Olympic Trials: A Battle with Pain

The preparation was mostly mental as I got ready for my first race. Unexpectedly, however, a male athlete that I greatly admired but had never spoken to noticed me as I was wrapping my foot, and spoke with me. He kindly gave me advice on how to treat my injury, and encouraged me not to give up on my dreams. For me, hearing those words was more than an honor — it was a need. I was halfway across the country, trying to make the best out of a bad situation, and the one person I never would have expected to notice saw me and chose to show compassion.

I took his words to heart and ran the first race, gritting my teeth through the pain. I made it all the way to the finals, which was wonderful considering my physical limitations. As I warmed up, I knew I wasn't going to qualify. I needed to be fully functional to run fast enough to meet the Olympic standard, but by that point, the race was no longer about that. After over a decade of determination, sacrifice, and unyielding hope, there was no way I could get this close and not run the finals. I had to finish it, even if I didn't win. I had to cross the finish line; not for anyone else — not even for the Olympics — but for *me*. So I did, agonizing as it was, with my heart in pieces — placing about 6th or 7th overall.

The Olympic Trials were undoubtedly the most difficult moment of my life, but it also taught me some invaluable lessons that I carried with me. I realized that some things aren't about winning, they're about finishing. Just to know that you did it, even if you didn't achieve what you wanted or get the opportunity you'd hoped for, can be so healing and prevent the regret that can gnaw so subtly as the years go by. It soothes the "What if?" questions and allows you to tell yourself, "Even so, I completed it. I have closure.":

Recovery and Reflection

I packed my bags and returned home for surgery and a year of healing, beginning a time of reflection on my career. Despite the numerous obstacles I faced during my professional career—hunger, homelessness, financial struggles, and sometimes, even a fear for my life—I took pride in my dedication and hard work. The mistreatment I endured in the track community,, especially from those I considered friends, was particularly painful. They viewed me as a threat and were willing to do anything to see me lose—lies, verbal abuse, anything. Still, I didn't let them break my spirit, and I was able to succeed despite the obstacles that came or were thrown my way.

The recovery period was filled with introspection and rebuilding. Healing physically was only part of the journey; I also had to confront the emotional and psychological scars left by both the injury and the betrayal of those I once trusted. This phase taught me the critical importance of self-care and forgiveness, as well as the strength found in solitude.

Redirecting Passion: Mentoring the Next Generation

Looking back, I wish I had been financially stable enough to continue Olympic training after my injury. However, instead of giving up, I used my work ethic to complete my education and establish a career. My life goals were simple: buy a vehicle, a home, and make as many trips as I could to visit my grandmother before she passed. Fortunately, I was able to achieve all three.

I also redirected my passion for sports towards mentoring the next generation of young athletes. Training youths in the community provided a new sense of purpose. Helping them set goals and navigate their own challenges allowed me to give back, and develop them into great people — both in sports and life.

Many of these young athletes succeeded in sports and university, and now they are all professional citizens I am proud of. Being a coach and mentor not only gave me a new direction but also gave me incredible joy in being able to use my skills and story to make an impact on others.

Chapter Five: Beyond the Finish Line

While my Olympic dreams did not fully materialize, the lessons I learned and the lives I touched through mentoring young athletes have been equally rewarding. Guiding youth to set and achieve their goals has instilled in me a profound sense of purpose and fulfillment that transcends personal achievements. Witnessing their success in sports and academics reaffirms my belief that the community is always a good investment — because you're not just impacting people, you're impacting generations.

Mentorship: A Pathway to Success

Mentorship became my way of ensuring that the legacy of my journey extended beyond my own story. By guiding others, I learned that true success isn't measured by trophies but by the ripple effect of one person's dedication to lifting up the next generation.

Life Lessons: More Than Medals

This journey has taught me that true success is not solely defined by medals and accolades, but by the impact we have on others and the strength we find within ourselves. Overcoming obstacles, adapting to new environments, and staying committed are the true markers of achievement.

The realization that true success encompasses personal growth and the positive influence we have on others has reshaped my perspective on achievement and fulfillment. It's not just about winning— but about leaving behind a legacy of strength, love, and changed lives.

Continuing the Journey: A Lifelong Pursuit

As I continue to move forward, I carry with me the memories, friendships, and lessons that have shaped who I am today. The journey does not end with the Olympic Trials; it evolves into a lifelong pursuit of personal growth, community service, and inspiring others to chase their own horizons.

Every challenge faced and every victory celebrated has contributed to a legacy of resilience, authenticity, and lasting happiness.

Though it was filled with obstacles, the road ahead remains open — filled with opportunities to continue growing, giving back, and uplifting others.

Conclusion

My journey isn't just a tale of athletic ambition but a testament to resilience, determination, and the power of community. From my early days training on the island to navigating the challenges of a new life in Canada, each step was driven by discipline and an unwavering focus on my goals.

The path was fraught with obstacles—relocation, financial struggles, injuries, and the loss of friendships—but each challenge strengthened my resolve. My experiences highlight the importance of perseverance, adaptability, and the support of a dedicated community. While my Olympic dreams were not fully realized, the lessons learned and the lives touched through mentoring young athletes have been equally rewarding.

This journey has taught me that success is not solely defined by medals and accolades but by the impact we have on others and the strength we find within ourselves. As I continue to move forward, I carry with me the memories, friendships, and lessons that have shaped who I am today.

Thank you for joining me on this journey. May my story inspire you to pursue your dreams with passion, overcome obstacles with grace, and cherish the support of your community, friends, and family.

Lessons Learned

- **Be okay if you have no support from those you thought were close to you.** Pull on your inner strength to get you through the emotional chaos, knowing you are all alone. In the end, you have to focus on yourself to run your race and achieve your goals in life.
- **Be even stronger knowing that those you called friends will turn on you to better their career while mocking yours.** The good thing is that at least now you know who your true friends are so you can build a strong support system.
- **Be creative and resourceful when you don't have enough.** Stay positive; things will get better.
- **The road to the goals can be lonely,** so learn how to motivate yourself and be at peace.
- **Tough decisions will have to be made,** just know it is for your best interest and you're still on the right path, even though you might not feel like it at the time.
- **Whatever the outcome,** learn the lesson and stay positive to focus on the decisions you now make for your life.
- **Be strong in whatever path you choose** and use your lessons to encourage yourself daily.
- **Know that it's okay to take a break.** Every journey has moments of exhaustion — it's by taking the time to heal and recover during those times that help you move forward.
- **Keep moving forward one step at a time and breathe.**
- **The end of one journey is only the beginning of another.**

It Takes Two — The Olympic Journey

On every journey in life, we all have others—someone in our lives who has sacrificed time to help us achieve our goal. Time that we cannot give back to them. Let's always remember them, be thankful for them, and celebrate them whenever we can. People such as grandparents, parents, siblings, teachers, pastors and church leaders, and most importantly, friends. Whether they've been on this journey with us from the beginning or later in the process — those who have taken the time to invest in us deserve recognition. When we win, *they* win, and that's what makes us stronger.

God bless you all!

About the Author

Former professional sprinter and Athletics coach Lornette Daye has spent her life uplifting others. Moving to Canada at ten years old from Jamaica, she gravitated to the wide range of sports the country offered. From basketball to swimming and even golf, Lornette had a keen interest in everything, but soon took off with Track and Field (now Athletics). Before 5 years old, she had many friendly competitions with her friends and enjoyed the feeling of running. Now in a new country, she was able to pursue her passion seriously, which led to her achieving both provincial and national titles, as well as records that are still unbroken.

Over the course of her new life in Canada, she never overlooked anyone who was struggling. She defended students who were bullied and took time out to encourage her teammates who weren't doing well. When she began training professionally, she dedicated hours to mentoring and supporting others, on and off the track. She recognized that success wasn't just about athletic achievement, but that doing well in school, having a strong support group, and being physically and mentally healthy were equally important, and contributed to how well they did in other areas. As a coach, she took it upon herself to help athletes achieve all-around success, including helping them reach their university and career goals.

After retiring from being an athlete, Lornette used her platform as a coach to pour into the younger generation and their families for over two decades — empowering her student-athletes to strive for excellence in every area of their lives and helping their families to support their athletic and personal lives.

After her athletic career, Lornette entered the corporate sector, becoming the top flight attendant at her company before transitioning to other industries. She founded multiple soccer and Track & Field clubs both in Canada and abroad, supported non-profit groups as a project coordinator to help them transform buildings into community hubs, and supported the roll out of fiber optics as a customer service coordinator for Shaw Communications (now Rogers). From business analysis to project management, Lornette used her skills to support any organization she was a part of.

She also became a certified Toastmasters speaker, where she uses her engagements to elevate and change lives. Lornette's mission has always been to speak to the soul of everyone she encounters, and to ensure that when her time with them is finished, they will leave with their lives better than when they came.